

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

◀ RAJKUMAR ROAT, *32*

| BAP | *Banswara (ST), Rajasthan*

This is one man who knows how to cut a dashing figure, whether attired in stylish tribal gear, or arriving in Parliament atop a camel to take oath as a new MP. He left the Bhartiya Tribal Party to float the Bharat Adivasi Party (BAP) in September 2023, only to have the party win three seats three months later in the Rajasthan assembly (he himself won from Chorasi, his second stint as legislator) and one in Madhya Pradesh. This year, he set his sights on the Lok Sabha, and here he is—the MP from Banswara. He has often called for an independent Bhil Pradesh, comprising the tribal belts of central India. Expect him to make a pitch in Parliament too.

His has been a slow and steady climb to the top. That includes being sarpanch, BJP's Chhotaudepur district president and vice-president of the party's Scheduled Tribe Morcha. The Lok Sabha election is a well-deserved culmination of his political innings, a satisfying one too with a winning margin of nearly 400,000 votes.

An executive member of the Karbi Anglong Autonomous Council—constituted under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution for development and protection of the tribal region—Tisso has studied till Class 12. His wife is an Assam state service officer.



▲ MURARI LAL MEENA, *65*

| CONGRESS | *Dausa (ST), Rajasthan*

Holding a civil engineering diploma, this seasoned tribal leader is a four-term MLA—twice as a BSP candidate and thereafter as the Congress's. Although his wife Savita failed to win the Dausa parliamentary seat in 2019, he avenged her defeat by wresting it from the BJP.



▲ S. SUPONGMEREN JAMIR, *61*

| CONGRESS | *Nagaland*

There cannot be a greater feat than securing a win for a party that doesn't have a single MLA in the 60-member assembly. That too after 25 years, and in the sole LS seat the state has. The kudos are well deserved for the state Congress chief.

DHAVAL LAXMANBHAI PATEL, *38* ▶

| BJP | *Valsad (ST), Gujarat*



A BTech in computer engineering, an MBA in marketing and stints with several top-notch MNCs—IBM, Capgemini, Accenture—across the US, Europe, Asia. But his calling, it seems, lay elsewhere. Ergo, a pivot to the BJP in 2021, and becoming the national social media in-charge of its Scheduled Tribe Morcha and also a popular right-wing voice in cyberspace. A book has followed too, on a favourite subject, *Bharat Ke Janjatiya Krantiveer*.



◀ JOBA MAJHI, *60* | JMM | *Singhbhum (ST), Jharkhand*

Wife of the late Devendra Manjhi, a leading tribal leader, Joba stepped into politics after he was murdered in 1994. Since 1995, this matriculate has represented Manoharpur in the Jharkhand assembly for five terms. A minister in the Hemant Soren government, she was dropped when Champai Soren took charge in February this year. But she was soon back in the reckoning and went on to defeat Geeta Kora, the sitting Congress MP who had switched to the BJP.

–Rohit Parihar, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Amitabh Srivastava, Jumana Shah and Kaushik Deka